An Aesthetics of Trauma

The Significance of Post-Traumatic Architecture

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From the earliest colonies, to redlining, to the hypergentrification of San Francisco's neighborhoods in the 21st Century, our country is one carved out through processes of exclusion and marginalization. Every stage of American history can be outlined by the new structures achieving these processes in each stage: slave plantations structured the geography of the American South, Reservations delineated what land belongs to those here first, the building of missions transformed the west coast, segregation determined by skin color how people oriented themselves to public spaces. The very foundation of our national space is one developed from the seed of white supremacy. We should not be mistaken in thinking that this history is behind us, it is here under our very feet. The trauma of white supremacy's germination in the American soil bears fruit to this day, determining along racial lines the meaning and significance of the world each and every one of us finds as "our own."

White supremacy haunts the very aesthetic of this nation, it is the skeletal structure under the bloated and disfigured face of American culture. James Baldwin once wrote that, "People are trapped in history and history is trapped in them."[i] The two problems are one and the same, we need to understand how to open the gates to these traps before a future is possible. To do this we need to first understand the trap itself.

This paper attempts to provide a preliminary sketch of concepts pertaining to a type of traumatic relation to the world for building an idea of post-traumatic architecture. The latter idea is intended to indicate the traumatic significance given to the spatiality of places tied to specific

histories, here focusing on the structures of violent racial marginalization and exclusion constructed throughout American history. A characterization of post-traumatic architecture makes it possible to draw a discussion around the differing racial experiences of physical space, such that, for people of color in the U.S. there is an immediate engagement with one's world that presents it as recalling that very trauma of exclusion, offering a world that says "you are in danger because you are not welcome here," around every corner. Thus, it is through trauma that world is filtered.

This current paper builds out three concepts that will be contained within the broader idea of post-traumatic architecture. First, I will introduce a discussion of Marianne Hirsch's concept of postmemory, providing insight into the cross-generational significance of trauma's impact. From there I will dive deeper into understanding the sites of postmemory through psychoanalyst Robert Stolorow's discussion of traumatic temporality. This will show that the order of difference in experience is not just spatial but temporal as well. In encountering post-traumatic architecture, victims of that trauma are present in a world bearing the significance it once had within the context that produced that trauma, not one that has moved on from it. Finally, I will show that this encounter with such a site not only brings the historical trauma to the surface but the surfacing itself triggers a secondary, second-order kind of trauma which will be discussed through George Atwood's notion of epistemological trauma. This will hopefully begin to show more of the radical differences in meaning the cultural aesthetic provides for our world.

Something peculiar has been observed by those studying cultural trauma: its haunting does not end with the generation present in that trauma, it lingers and persists within the lives of the successive generations—seemingly without end. This phenomenon is what Marianne Hirsch has named "postmemory." She describes its experience and generative process saying that,

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> Postmemory describes the relationship that the generation after those who witnessed cultural or collective trauma bears to the experiences of those who came before, experiences that they "remember" only by means of the stories, images, and behaviors among which they grew up. But these experiences were transmitted to them so deeply and affectively as to seem to constitute memories in their own right. Postmemory's connection to the past is thus not actually mediated by recall but by imaginative investment, projection, and creation. To grow up with such overwhelming inherited memories, to be dominated by narratives that preceded one's birth or one's consciousness, is to risk having one's own stories and experiences displaced, even evacuated, by those of a previous generation. It is to be shaped, however indirectly, by traumatic events that still defy narrative reconstruction and exceed comprehension. These events happened in the past, but their effects continue into the present.[ii]

In describing its post-ness, Hirsch is indicating here that postmemory entails a temporal delay, a location in an aftermath, a distance, and an interrelation with the present—a "s*tructure* of inter- and trans-generational transmission of traumatic knowledge and experience" similar to the recall in PTSD, but at a generational remove.[iii]

Sandra So Hee Chi Kim explains that while postmemory is not a literal memory, it is approximate to memory in its kind of affective force.[iv] She points out that postmemory can be shaped by speech, as well as the silence of mourning, there is a language of the home family that exceeds the verbal and is a language of the body which forcefully communicates the symptoms of trauma within the familial space.

For Kim, postmemory complicates the dichotomy between individual and collective memories and presents "the idea that *one's past can be passed on to another*."[v] It indicates that postmemory is a phenomenon in which "the consciousnesses involved in the intentional act multiply, making the subjectivity behind the *noesis* and the *noema* plural and discontinuous." In contrast to memory, postmemory is a work of recollection which makes significant use of the imagination.[vi]

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Postmemory presents itself as a hybrid of the world of experience and the world of fantasy.[vii] The absent world that manifests itself for the subject of postmemory does so in a different way: they imagine worlds,

> actively *conjure up* places, situations and bodies from which it is not only temporally discontinuous, but also spatially, culturally, and/or linguistically so. Instead of reconstructing a memory-image from 'pure memory,' postmemory relies on a kind of analogical imaging that takes the memories communicated by another person and translates them through an existing visual archive of private and public images.[viii]

Thus postmemory is radically offset conceptually from memory within phenomenology, produced "under the context of affect in relation to the Other."[ix]

What I want to claim here is that the experience of postmemory is primarily a dissociative experience, in the sense that Robert Stolorow gives to dissociation as a "traumatic temporality."[x] Such encounters with memory are given over via portkeys, those objects which "return one again and again to an experience of traumatization."[xi] Stolorow describes the effect of trauma on temporality as disrupting the "ordinary, average-everyday linearity and 'ecstatically unity of temporality[.]'"[xii] In this, the traumatic experiences are "freeze-framed into an eternal present in which one remains forever trapped, or to which one is condemned to be perpetually returned through [portkeys]."[xiii] The person so affected "quite literally lives in another kind of reality, an experiential world felt to be incommensurable with those of others," which "contributes to the sense of alienation and estrangement from other human beings that typically haunts the traumatized person."[xiv]

By connecting this notion of the dissociative experience of traumatic temporality to postmemory, in which the latter is a case of the former class, the transmission of this experience can be more easily understood. Within individual memory, always situated with respect to other people and places, the collective is always present. Memory always recalls the social milieu in

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which the original event was experienced. The individual consciousness analogically transfers to the Other, leading to a foundational intersubjectivity.

Echoing Husserl, Kim makes note that, "the Other is constituted from the 'sphere of ownness,' a reduction in which one abstracts everything in one's experience that is an experience of Otherness, leaving only what is mine."[xv] Intentionalities are formed which transcend one's own being, and "The objective world is statically constituted as already finished and alien to the *ego*, and the possibility of the experience of the world as alien comes, first, from the possibility of experiencing the *alter ego* as Other." Kim makes use of Ricoeur's concept of social communalization and the communalization of subjective experience: we are given a community of Others "and then the world is 'there' for any member of this community."

In brief this means that the portkeys themselves can be shared by those present in the trauma and that the successive generations following those present can have the portkeys and their corresponding experience transferred to them. This is what takes place in the phenomenon of postmemory, the aesthetic structure of the post-traumatic world is a frozen frame of the experience itself that brings those who come after to that trauma through the portkeys that still bear meaning to them. There is an experience of this prior trauma as present and mapped on to the world in which they are immersed. Our world reproduces trauma. This is the source of the memory, the postmemory, of these events in successive generations.

The effect of postmemory is exacerbated by the radical discontinuity between the present world and the trauma frozen within it. It is not just the trauma transferred in postmemory that is felt but the additional trauma of finding out one's world is not what we assume it is in our daily life. This forms a secondary kind of traumatization, a second-order trauma that should not be ignored, dismissed, or excluded from our understanding of the encounter with postmemory.

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In *The Abyss of Madness*, George Atwood invokes the term "epistemological trauma" to describe those events undercutting "someone's faith in what previously had been believed to be true. It is an event or situation in person's life that contradicts what had theretofore been a matter of the given or even pregiven," producing the vertiginous experience of "the shattering of confidence of one's own mind."[xvi] In the two case studies he provides of this kind of trauma he examines the way in which the trust in oneself is so undermined that it produces a radical pain moving one towards self-annihilation—merely an externalization of the annihilation brought to their interiority.

An encounter with something that radically disturbs the structure making it possible for one to come to know about their world provokes a plunge into a hell that perhaps none ever fully return from. Our world provides us with a somewhat stable ground for our basic presumptions about our lives and our situations. To have this foundation crumble is profoundly traumatic itself and within the context of post-traumatic architecture only serves to amplify the originary trauma itself. It is a plunge into a surreality where agency is lost because the very subject capable of being an agent has become unmoored and no longer has an anchor point for meaning.

The profoundly disturbing nature of epistemological trauma needs to be understood if we are to begin to have a full understanding of what is being investigated here. Binswanger provides more insight into this experience,

> When, in a bitter disappointment, "we fall from the clouds," then we fall—we actually fall. Such falling is neither purely of the body nor something metaphorically derived from physical falling. Our harmonious relationship with the world and the [people] about us suddenly suffers a staggering blow, stemming from the nature of bitter disappointment and the shock that goes with it. In such a moment our existence actually suffers, is torn from its position in the world and thrown upon its own resources. Until we can regain our equilibrium in the world, our whole existence moves within the meaning matrix of stumbling, sinking, and falling. If we call this general meaning matrix the "form," and the bitter disappointment the "content," we can see that in this case form and content are one.[xvii]

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This is the way in which the encounter with prior trauma via postmemory can become so damaging: that prior trauma itself is felt along with the epistemological trauma that comes about as a result of its disruption of one's world. The person's affect is shape by the encounter and has no resources left onto which they can be thrown. They become a victim of the historical sites they encounter, and this includes encounters with the absurd monuments to confederate soldiers littering the landscape of the American South.

The insight given here is not unique, it is something we can find voiced by many who move about our world and encounter it in such a way. The hope here is that this helps shed light upon such traumatic phenomena for those of us who are excluded from such experiences in the world. This is what I hear when listening to Toni Morrison, writing on her idea of rememory in *Beloved* say,

> I was talking about time. It's so hard for me to believe in it. Some things go. Pass on. Some things just stay. I used to think it was my rememory. You know. Some things you forget. Other things you never do. But it's not. Places, places are still there. If a house burns down, it's gone, but the place—the picture of it—stays, and not just in my rememory, but out there, in the world. What I remember is a picture floating around out there outside my head. I mean, even if I don't think it, even if I die, the picture of what I did, or knew, or saw is still out there. Right in the place where it happened. […] Someday you be walking down the road and you hear something or see something going on. So clear. And you think it's you thinking it up. A thought picture. But no. It's when you bump into a rememory that belongs to somebody else. Where I was before I came here, that place is real. It's never going away. Even if the whole farm—every tree and grass blade of it dies. The picture is still there and what's more, if you go there—you who never was there—if you go there and stand in the place where it was, it will happen again; it will be there for you, waiting for you. So, Denver, you can't never go there. Never. Because even though it's all over—over and done with—it's going to always be there waiting for you.[xviii]

[i] Baldwin, James. "Stranger in the Village." In *Notes of a Native Son*. Boston: Beacon Press, 2012.
[ii] Hirsch, Marianne. "The Generation of Postmemory." *Poetics Today* 29, no. 1 (2008): 103-28. doi:10.1215/03335372-2007-019. 106-07

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[iii] *Ibid.* 106
[iv] Kim, Sandra So Hee Chi. "Redefining Diaspora through a Phenomenology of Postmemory." 339.
[v] *Ibid.*. 340.
[vi] *Ibid.* .342
[vii] *Ibid.*.343
[viii] *Ibid.*
[ix] *Ibid.* 345
[x] Stolorow, Robert. *World, Affectivity, Trauma.* 54
[xi] *Ibid.* 55
[xii] *Ibid.*
[xiii] *Ibid.*
[xiv] *Ibid.* 55-56
[xv] Kim. p.347.
[xvi] Atwood, George. *The Abyss of Madness*. 73
[xvii] Binswanger, Ludwig. "Dream and Existence." In *Being-in-the-World: Selected Papers of Ludwig Binswanger*. New York: Basic Books, pp. 222-248. 223
[xviii] Morrison, Toni. *Beloved.* 35-36

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